



Photo by Jack Plankett

Toni Lockett:

Her eyes are on the prize

By Martin Rincon

Toni Lockett has devised the commensurate plan to combat the UT administration's reluctance for change. "By any means necessary." Her job she said ultimately, "is to facilitate change on this campus." Probably the only

Students' Association President ever to receive death threats, Lockett's 1960's idealism ignites a renewed sense

of activism throughout the campus. Already it inspires such projects as Proposed Reforms to Institute Diversity in Education (PRIDE) and Todos Unidos, a Chicano agenda coalition.

Asked if she was surprised by victory in the Students' Association elections Lockett exclaims, "Shit yeah!" This uncommon president, already immersed in recent protests against Round-Up '90's racist incidents, feverishly advocates attacking cultural illiteracy with curriculum reform including required multicultural classes.

To the astonishment of students and administrators alike, Lockett became the new Students' Association President in a narrow victory in the closest race and highest voter turnout in UT history.

Lockett, a 24 year-old native born Austinite, is a senior in African/African-American studies. The youngest of five and first to attend college in her family, she transferred from Indiana State University with a 3.7 GPA. She supports herself with scholarships, student loans and odd jobs throughout the year. "I'll do anything I can get," she says.

"All my friends are activists" as Lockett explains the rationale for her activism, "so I just got activated."

Lockett maintains a volume of activity that makes interviewing her most challenging. Arriving at 12:12 Monday afternoon for a 11:30 appointment, Lockett

whisked into her office as an associate handed her a stack of phone messages. Crayon graffiti cover the walls of her office: "Let there be Light!" and "It's a black thing; But you must understand."

The office pulsed like the nerve center of an underground revolutionary movement. Cohorts ran in and out of the office interrupting constantly. Shellin cigarette, then vaulted into commanding voice and

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easy articulation.

"It's a good year to be at UT," she pronounced, "a lot of good things going on." Near, Lockett joked "we'll ask the administration if we can take over the Tower."

Lockett proposes one of the most progressive agendas for real change ever offered to University administration, from heading off tuition increases for graduate students to total divestment from South African portfolios. Most importantly, she advocates diversification of UT curriculum.

"We want to eliminate ignorance on campus and the best way to deal with that problem is to diversify curriculum," Lockett said. "Our educational process at this point is very flawed."

Lockett believes the "oppressive" social system, which disables minorities, will ultimately "be its own undoing," and she goes on, "Lack of understanding of other cultures is what is going to destroy America." Lockett dismisses that racist acts of the "Fiji" and "Delt" fraternities reflect a society tolerant of such hostilities and minor "symptoms of a system gone bad." She says that the one-year ban against these fraternities' association with campus, demanded by the Black Students Association, holds legitimacy.

In Lockett's opinion, most University problems could be eliminated if the administration reprimands effectively. If they do not she says, "It will be to their own detriment."

Lockett, who is less than enthusiastic about working with the administration, especially President William Cunningham, states that the UT students count on her abilities to engage in effective dialogue and force change. "It's time for the president and the Board of Regents to dedicate themselves to creating an educational system that is worthy of the UT name."

April 15, when Cunningham addressed 1500 students about University policies on the fraternity actions, provides a clear example of the mindset that Lockett says she must overcome.

"Cunningham doesn't give the students any credit...he's trying to sugar coat the issues," she says referring to Cunningham's poor effort to camouflage the main issues of curriculum diversity by trying to provide an image of support from

blacks. As an example she describes Cunningham's recruited message of Professor Ruben McDaniel from Graduate Management Department, the new Assistant Vice Provost George Wright, and UT football Coach David McWilliams among others to stand with him at the podium.

"He wants people to look at his group and go 'Hey, he's multicultural!'" How many times have you seen President Cunningham with four black men? Lockett thinks that by such public relation gimmicks the president tries to undermine student solidarity. But, she says, "We are not stupid!"

Cunningham receives low marks from Lockett for playing the Administration's "front-man." An independent Cunningham, she says, should "deal with tensions on campus" and "set tone" for necessary policy and curriculum changes.

Lockett says that having seized the initiative, students

"need to get out there with a vengeance, and keep the administration on the run at any cost..." Lockett also noted that more assertive actions might be appropriate. "Sit-ins and take overs are effective," but she said, the 1986 "UT 16" takeover of Cunningham's office was "not planned well."

Whatever happens next she said, "It's not my call...it's the BSA's. I'm a member of BSA but I don't call the shots."

However, she did not rule out any non-traditional methods of coaxing Cunningham, sit-ins, class boycotts, etc, forcing administrative policy changes "by any means necessary."

Lockett works under some hazards, though. She asks aides, "Walk me to class, people will beat me up." Her political views she explains make her a target. "We [minorities] have learned historically that when the norm is

disturbed, the majority apparatus usually comes down on you hard." Recently Lockett has been the target of various threats, racist mail, vandalism to her car, and obscene telephone calls.

"We want your nigger ass dead!"

She believes the goals are worth the risk, says this activist lesbian. "I think everyone has a role to play in the movement." She hopes that her model will allow others to follow in the struggle for equality and education of society.

Ironically, Lockett's rebellion has just begun as the semester ends. "I'm counting the days, then I'm going on a long vacation."

Pellets may sway the SA president, but Lockett remains "Keep alive, keep your eyes on the prize."

Herrera:

Jerse Herrera, a photojournalism graduate student, will exhibit his photography analyzing popular life around Puebla, Mexico, through May 15 at the Denise Lee Benson Latin American Collection Library.

"La Reina del Huipil," or "Popular Expression in Cuernavaca, Puebla," will be featured at the display area within Sid Richardson Hall.

Herrera, a professional photographer at the Texas Department of Agriculture, also photographed Mexican Parades for the December issue of Texas.

"Unfortunately," said Luis Lopez, editor, "the credit line was inadvertently removed."